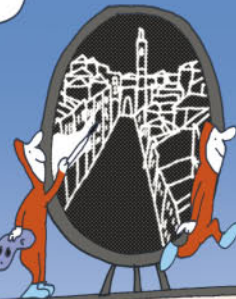


The Balkans

With the exception of Albania, the countries of the Balkans are relatively young, having emerged as independent states from 1991 onward. So far, none are members of the EU.



Croatia

The Adriatic coastline of Croatia contains many old towns, such as Dubrovnik, popular with tourists and sailors.



Bosnia

Originally built in 1566 and traditionally used as a diving platform for young men to prove their bravery, Bosnia's famous Mostar Bridge was restored in 1994.

Macedonia

The capital, Skopje, of this mountainous, landlocked republic lies in an earthquake zone and has been destroyed four times in its history.

Fifth time's the charm!



Top spot!

Montenegro

Montenegro ("Black Mountain") became one of the world's newest states after gaining independence from Serbia in 2006.

Serbia

The Serbs are Orthodox Christians and share a language with the Croats, although they use different scripts to write it down.



Right on the mark.

ST. MARK'S CHURCH, BELGRADE, SERBIA

Albania

Known by its people as "the land of the eagles," Albania is largely agricultural with most Albanians working on the land for a living.

Look what's crapped up!

Mine's still an underground phenomenon.



Romania and Moldova

Once united as a single country, Romania and Moldova are surrounded by mainly Slav-speaking and Cyrillic-writing states, yet they speak and write a language (Romanian) more like French or Italian.

Moldova

The rich, black soil of Moldova is ideal for growing cotton, grapes, and sunflowers, the seeds of which are a valuable export crop.



Ukraine and Belarus

Both Ukraine—Europe's second largest country—and Belarus were once part of Russia. They gained their independence in 1991 and are largely flat and agricultural, although Ukraine also has substantial heavy industries.



MOTHERLAND STATUE, VOLGOGRAD, UKRAINE

Romania

The Carpathian Mountains separate Transylvania, home of the legendary Count Dracula, from the rest of the country, which lies along the Danube River valley.



SKIING IN THE CARPATHIANS

Flower power!

I'm an independent type.



Kiev
Ukraine's ancient capital was founded in the 9th century. Its most famous landmark is the gold-domed St. Sophia's Cathedral.



Belarus

The Pripyet Marshes in southern Belarus are the largest marshlands in Europe and are home to elk and wild boar.



Ukraine

The Donbass basin in eastern Ukraine is Europe's largest coalfield and supports massive iron and steel works, car plants, and other industries.

Where's the fire?

Don't be a boar.

Come on!



I hit my head and saw tsars!

Russian Federation

The largest nation on Earth, Russia stretches across both the European and Asian continents. Most people live in the towns and cities of western Russia.

St. Petersburg

The capital of the Russian Empire for 200 years, St. Petersburg was built by Peter the Great in the early 1700s as a "window to the west."

Watch out below!

Russian ballet

Russia is renowned for its ballet companies—the Kirov from St. Petersburg and the Bolshoi from Moscow.



Get to the pointe.

Hello, dolly!

MATRIOSHKA DOLLS

The Kremlin

A fortified citadel in the heart of Moscow, the Kremlin includes the palace of the former tsars. Today, the Russian government has its headquarters here.



ST. BASIL'S CATHEDRAL, MOSCOW

THE WINTER PALACE, ST. PETERSBURG

EXIT